that the country had to look elsewhere and might have to tighten food rations.[130] While she did not identify India's Vietnam policy as a reason for the delay, leaks from Washington suggested that was Johnson's motivation.[131] Resentment against US food policy only grew within and outside government.[132]

In India, aware of the socioeconomic and political implications of the intensifying food crisis, the prime minister instructed her officials to "avoid confrontation or debate" with the US on minor matters.[133] There were reports that she had tempered the nonaligned communiqué's language, eliminating Nasser's condemnation of the US.[134] And her government also cautioned the North Vietnamese representative in India against issuing a press release criticizing the US.[135]

Johnson told Rostow to tell the Indian ambassador that he could "make no commitment now but the Indians should keep quiet and have some faith."[136] After a congressional delegation returning from India recommended sending 1.8 million tons of food, Johnson in late December approved half that amount, which he thought could meet India's requirements through February. Eventually, he decided that in a speech just before the Indian elections due in late February, he would announce a commitment of 1 million tons of grain.[137]

Given the upcoming elections, Indian policymakers warned that the approved amount was "politically dangerous."[138] US policy toward India opened Gandhi up to criticism during the election campaign and put her on the defensive. In January, when the Indian government agreed to further restrictions on trade with Cuba and North Vietnam because US legislation required it, critics alleged that Gandhi had accepted "humiliating conditions." Krishna Menon, running as an independent, accused her of continually giving in to pressure and asserted, "This rot must stop." After initially trying to explain her policy on the basis of pragmatism—noting that India's choice was to accept the conditions or refuse the food—she subsequently turned to denying that she was succumbing to pressure, asserting, "We would rather starve than sell our national honour."[139]

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